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Using Popular Culture to Promote Critical Literacy Practices

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We began this study with one overarching question: What do children (fifth-graders) and preservice teachers (PTs) already know about the critical reading of advertisements from which we might build a critically literate curriculum? Imbedded within this question were two smaller questions: 1) What visual elements do viewers pay attention to and which discourses do they identify with as they read advertisements? and 2) What do the participants' interpretations of these ads offer us as insight for creating curriculum?

Popular culture produces texts which are attractive to large numbers of children. In this new literacy age, Kress (2003) noted that images are replacing writing as the dominant form of meaning-making and that the screen is becoming the new page. In support of this change, he argues that "the world told" is vastly different from "the world shown" (p. 1). This visual world with its range of texts (advertisements, TV, films, internet sites, billboards, etc.), argued Carr (2000), must be interrogated by even the youngest of children who can examine and identify significant concepts, symbols, and systems of representation. The connection between literacy and popular culture has been investigated by a number of scholars (Alvermann, 2001; Alvermann, Hagood, & Williams, 2003; Beach, 2007; Harste, Albers, Vander Zanden, & Felderman, 2007; Haas-Dyson, 1997; Marsh, 2006; Steinberg & Kincheloe, 2004; Walkerdine, 1990). They collectively described the influence of superheroes, music, videos, video games, advertisements, Internet sites, books, and toys (to name a few) in shaping the identities of children and teens. Steinberg and Kincheloe (2004) and Beach (2007), in particular, argued that we have become a culture of consumerism; corporations, with or without our consent, defining and shaping through their products the identities they believe children and youth want to become. In essence, Beach suggested, consumers buy into lifestyles that are represented through ads, and demand or desire (especially young consumers) products because they will make their lives better, regardless of the impact on environment (depletion of resources), ideologies (industries such as oil, coal, beef, etc. are good for us despite global warming effects), and health (obesity and fast foods). Advertisements as popular culture, like products mentioned above, add to the shaping of identities, real or imagined, that consumers wish to take on, conscious or unconscious, as part of their everydayness. Even though these scholars argue for student critique of media texts, little opportunity is provided, as such engagements are considered not academically rigorous (Marsh, 2006). Like these scholars, we believe it is never too early to start helping students critically analyze and develop frames for talking about popular culture (Lewison, Leland, & Harste,

2008) which includes advertisements. When the dominant discourse relating to literacy instruction is centered on topics like phonemic awareness, there is little motivation for teachers to design literacy curricula that focus more broadly on issues, such as helping kids understand how they are being positioned as a huge new consumer market by popular culture. Rather than advocate building an understanding of critical literacy upon the analytic abilities that teachers and children already possess, many critical literacy theorists write as if one is starting from scratch. We take issue with this stance. Scarino (2000) argued that culture, itself (and we include popular culture), is constructed as a matter of observation and individuals' transactions with it. To understand individuals' interpretation and response to popular culture is to recognize that their own viewpoints are culturally determined—attitudes, values, beliefs and emotions. Attention to these beliefs from a critical literacy perspective offers a tool for moving students towards these understandings.

This study builds on the work going on in how we, as a culture, read visual texts. Specifically, it uses advertisements, texts created by those who target particular audiences with the intention of generating desired readings through image, structure, and message, and who rely on assumptions about what is collectively known, valued, and experienced by that target audience. In this study, we examined how children and preservice teachers read advertisements to understand what they already know about being critically literate and to understand the values, beliefs, and discourses to which they attended. We generated a set of instructional engagements which built upon their ability to critique, more collectively and thoughtfully, both the visual and written messages. We drew upon visual discourse analysis (Albers, 2007) to unpack their readings, and to identify graphic, syntactic, pragmatic, semantic, and textual elements which they found significant in these texts.

Awareness of power relations and intentions, both visual and written, that underpin advertisements is critical and must be an everyday part of literacy instruction. Advertisements support a capitalistic perspective of the world (Beach, 2007), and the design and marketing of such products generates a population of viewers who desire the lifestyle, the product, or the object being sold. Such awareness, Beach (2007) argued, will challenge the larger economic system built on consumerism. Edelsky (1999) suggested that an initial step in making social justice our project is realizing that we need first to become aware ourselves and then to support children in developing an awareness of the larger social systems which are in place. These systems are often taken-for-granted and frame our perception and sensibilities, or lack of the same. By interrogating the visual and written relationships within advertisements, viewers, young and older, can more thoughtfully discuss and understand the complex and multi-faceted nature of such texts, and of a culture itself.

OVERVIEW OF THE STUDY

This study evolves from our years of careful study of written texts from a critical perspective, as well as from a close examination of the visual texts produced by students and teachers in classroom settings, and from our need to extend this conversation to texts such as advertisements that populate our visual lives (Albers, 2007; Albers & Harste, 2007; Harste, Leland, Grant, Chung, & Enyeart, 2007). Analytical work that focuses on close readings of such texts is significant for two reasons. First, understanding literacy practices requires a thoughtful and systematic study of the variety of representations found in everyday texts, including multimodal texts such as advertisements (Harste,

Albers, Vander Zanden, & Felderman, 2007). An analysis of the tensions between the desired readings and viewers' own interpretation of advertisements offers insight into how viewers generate new understandings about their own cultural situatedness. Second, analyses of relationships between and among objects within a visual text—what semioticians call “signs”—along with a holistic reading of the often implicit overall text, provide information about how texts position readers as well as encourage readers to take on certain identities, values, and ideologies other than their own. The net result of such analyses is an emerging understanding of a culture's everyday literacy practices. All this is to say that visual representations, including those found in advertisements, must be viewed in light of the ideological messages being conveyed, visible or hidden. Put simply, the unique message-generating capacity of the visual arts media themselves no longer can be ignored.

Visual Discourse Analysis: Theoretical and Methodological Considerations for Reading and Interpreting Popular Culture Texts

Located within semiotics (Hodge & Kress, 1988), discourse analysis (Gee, 2005), and the grammar of visual design (Kress & van Leeuwen, 1996), visual discourse analysis (VDA) (Albers, 2007) is a general term for an approach to analyzing art as a language and its use, especially as it relates to popular culture texts. It is concerned with a theory and method of studying the structures and conventions within visual texts and identifying how certain social activities and social identities get played out in their production. More specifically, visual discourse analysts attend closely to semiotic aspects of texts, including the marks on visual texts within the constructs of art as a language system and how these marks are interpreted within said texts. Such study invites a semiotic approach, or one in which there is an attempt to describe an overall structural organization of art as a language system (Saussure, 1916), and the social contexts in which meanings are produced (Hodge & Kress, 1988).

Semiotics is a theory that explores the nature and function of signs as well as the systems and processes underlying signification, expression, representation, and communication. It offers a way of thinking about meaning in which written/oral language and visual texts work in concert, and in which written/oral language is not the primary source through which meaning is mediated and represented. Hodge and Kress (1988) defined a text as “a structure of messages or message traces which has a socially ascribed unity” (p. 6), and discourse is seen as ideological and “refers to the social process in which texts are embedded.” They continued, “text is the material object produced in discourse” (p. 6). A visual text, then, is a structure of messages within which are embedded social conventions and/or perceptions, and present a particular discourse community, one with whom the visual text maker wants you to identify (Albers, 2007). According to Halliday (1985), texts are in a dialectal relation with context; the text creates the context as much as the context creates the text. Meaning arises from the friction between the two.

Visual discourse analysis, like discourse analysis, addresses the discourses that present themselves within visual text, as well as the viewers' identification with these discourses. The visual text, then, is a communicative event, one that elicits and invites viewers to participate vicariously in the lived worlds of those in popular culture texts (Vasquez, 2003). Several semiotic principles underpin visual discourse analysis, informed by Gee's (2005) work in discourse analysis. First, visual language is reflexive in that it has the capacity both to create and to reflect the context and reality in which it was created. The viewer is implicated to the degree of her or his familiarity with the

context, as well as messages sent and interpreted by the viewer. Second, language allows for situated meanings to occur. That is, interpretations of visual texts are “assembled on the spot” (Gee, 2005, p. 94) in a given context and based upon previous experiences. Third, language is composed of many different social languages (Bakhtin, 1981), and visual designers and artists use different tools or media through which to communicate or carry out their intended message. And last, there are units of analysis within visual texts, including structural, semantic, artistic, tactile, and visual, that engage viewers into noticing particular aspects of a visual text more than others (size, volume, color, line, etc.).

Inherently embedded in VDA is the concept of the critical perspective (Janks, 2000) in which visual texts can and do indicate the designer’s or artist’s beliefs about power, how objects in the visual text mean, what larger social meanings are referenced, and what particular structures give access to whom for what purpose. For us, visual discourse analysis provides both a methodological and a theoretical framework around which to study the interpretations and responses generated by preservice teachers and fifth-grade students while reading popular culture texts, specifically, advertisements.

METHOD

This qualitative study of the reading of advertisements by preservice teachers (N=21) and fifth-grade students (N=11) was conducted at the beginning of the 2007 school year. Preservice teachers were enrolled in a reading and language arts methods class at a major Midwestern university in the U.S. As is typical of preservice teachers at this university, the sample was female, white, and middle class. Fifth-graders were enrolled in a public school outside of our nation’s capital. While a variety of ethnicities were represented, all of the students were children of blue- and white-collar workers.

At the end of the 2006 school year, we conducted a pilot study in a preservice and fifth-grade classroom for purposes of deciding which advertisements to use and what procedures to use in data collection. Both groups were aware of and practiced critical readings of texts. We initially used 12 advertisements that we thought would demand a critical reading, but we found this number to be too many and several to be too controversial to use in elementary classrooms. This was especially true if we did not wish to spend a lot of time justifying our choices. For example, we initially had a Levi Straus ad in which a drug addicted-like teen was shown provocatively wearing a pair of jeans, an ad celebrating the drinking of Canadian beer by a group of young people; a skateboard ad where a teen was shown, from behind, using it as a foot stool to urinate in a bathroom urinal; and a Skechers Footwear ad in which the teen in the photo was shown sitting on a young girl’s lap, but where the girl was about to bite him in a vampire-like pose. Both the teens, of course, were wearing Skechers Footwear. Procedurally, we allowed participants in the pilot study just to talk about these ads in any way they wished. After their conversation, we asked them to write down what was said. This procedure resulted in too much lost information. Videotaping did not solve the problem as conversations overlapped and were too hard to hear. While having participants write their answers to questions no doubt restricted what participants had to say, we elected to go for this more controlled data collection procedure to capture their individual readings of these ads. We also

decided, as a result of this pilot study, and given the intent of this study, to collect data in classrooms new to critical literacy.

We wanted both to describe the content of what these participants saw as well as to analyze their acts of interpretation. Our concern went beyond recording their final interpretation or last words. We wanted to understand the meanings they generated while reading the ad. Said differently, we wanted to understand what viewers were bringing to the ad for purposes of noting how these resources affected and were used to reach a final interpretation.

Procedures

We presented eight professional advertisements found in a range of common magazines (*Skater Magazine*, *Parents*, *Sports Illustrated*) and everyday texts (flyers advertising Home Depot paint samples, an Internet ad advertising Big Macs targeted at teens), scanned each of them, and imported them into PowerPoint. Like the ads in our pilot study, we included these ads because we read them as demanding a critical reading. That is, we chose ads that presented visual and language content in ways that might elicit a critical response to issues of gender (sex, color, position in home or career), overt sexual messages, acceptance of war as everyday experience and responsibility of young men and women, and lifestyles. By intentionally selecting such ads, we could better understand whether the designers of the ads had, indeed, been successful in either masking or eliciting their intended response. Participants were asked to study the ad and to record their responses without consultation with others engaged in this research project. At the end of the first set of four slides and at the end of a second set of four slides, participants were shown all of the slides in that set and asked to identify in writing which ad was their favorite in this set and why. All participants viewed each ad for approximately one minute and then responded in writing to three questions:

- What do you think the developers of this advertisement want you to buy?
- How are they trying to convince you to do that?
- (And after seeing a set of 4 ads) Which of these is your favorite and why do you like it or think that someone else would like it?

Asking participants to respond to which ad they thought was their favorite enabled us to better understand which content and/or artistic elements participants reacted to, and how their reactions might suggest the favorable reactions of others. That is, did they like the ad because of the colors? The content? The models? The message? Such identification of elements enabled us to more systematically analyze their responses as critical or not critical.

Advertisements Studied

Home Depot paint swatches. Two sets of paint swatches are presented, one aimed at colors for boys and one for girls. Paint swatches for boys are in the shape of a Mickey Mouse hat, in three bold colors (red, black and blue). A flyer depicts these paints in a bedroom scene featuring a smiling boy of approximately six years of age. Paint swatches for girls move from pastel to bold (yellow, pink, red), all in the shape of glass slippers. In a close-up shot on this flyer, a young girl smiles as she wears a princess crown in her newly painted bedroom, trimmed in pink flowers.

Ralph Lauren for children. A young girl, wearing a flowered sleeveless dress with a hunter green sweater casually thrown over her shoulders (a classical let's play tennis look), stands near a beach in profile and smiles slightly and directly at the viewer.

Wal-Mart's Barbie clothing collection for girls. Marching confidently down a runway, three smiling girls are dressed in various shades of pink clothing (skirts, tops, stockings). Images of Barbie dolls and accessories that complement the outfits run in the margins of the ad.

Skechers footwear. A smiling Carrie Underwood, casually dressed in Capri pants and wearing Skechers shoes, sits on the floor in her bedroom surrounded by multiple pairs of shoes and golden retriever puppies, one of which she holds in her left arm while holding a shoe in her right hand.

Fila shoes. Against a black, electric blue and white backdrop, Jerry Stackhouse dribbles a basketball directly towards the viewer, with two shadowed images of himself playing basketball, one that looks to the left and one that looks to the right of the central image. White text, cascading downward on the picture, reads: "7 brothers 3 sisters 1 bathroom. No wonder Jerry Stackhouse has such a quick first step."

Britney 4 wheelers. Against a blue, white and red backdrop, three suggestive poses of Britney Spears (two facing the viewer, one facing to the left), with midriff showing and wearing roller blades, face the viewer. The ad positions the viewer to read the picture upwards and towards Britney's midriff.

Army ad. A young man, in a close-up shot, about 18 years old and wearing a baseball cap, faces the viewer looking very serious. Slightly blurred and faded, the father, behind and to the right of his son and also wearing a baseball cap, looks at his son; the ad is in sepia tones. The message on the bottom reads: "You always hoped he would end up running with the right crowd, but did you ever think he'd also be leading it?"

Big Mac ad. Against a backdrop of browns and red, a large image of a Big Mac is on right with the words, all in caps, "MY BUNS DEMAND BOTH HANDS," with "BOTH" in a much larger font on the left side of the ad.

Data Collection and Analysis

Data sets included eight advertisements and the responses generated from participants from their viewing of these ads. Data was collected from one elementary classroom in the East and one preservice teacher (PT) class in the Midwest. Participants were given a form on which to record their response to each of the research questions for each of the ads shown. Jerry, Sarah, and Carol collected the data and, guided by our research questions, did an initial analysis of the responses that each of the participants gave. We generated lists of what participants noticed: visual elements (for example: colors used, visible icons, logos, smiling faces), products being sold (for example: shoes, Barbie line clothing, sophisticated lifestyle), structure of ad (for example, large font, large images, gazes and expressions of people featured in ads), and discourses of consumerism (for example, mention of participants' desire to have that object). Jerry then categorized these responses into major themes, and asked the teachers involved in this study, Sarah and Carol, to do a critique of these themes and draw conclusions from this analysis. Independent of Jerry, Sarah and Carol, Peggy read/reread these ads using visual discourse analysis, and coded both sets of data in light of what was noticed and mentioned by participants as significant: setting (for example: outdoor scenes, calm scene, beautiful rooms), gazes of people in ads (for example: demand and offer), value-laden

descriptors (for example, PTs describe children in ads as cute, little, beautiful; fifth-graders describe children as boy or girl), critical/not critical response to ad (for example, PTs mention “pretty young, fashionable, little girls” walking the runway, coded not critical), desired readings and if creators of ad achieved their goal (for example, fifth-graders did not see themselves as the target audience for Disney colors).

After these initial and independent attempts at coding and analysis, we then met together, and shared our findings. To answer the first and second questions, what is being sold and how do they convince you to do this, we paid close attention both to the physical or visible elements participants identified, as well as the invisible messages or discourses that they saw in this ad. To answer the third question, or what they liked about the ad, we paid particular attention to art elements and structural design elements participants mentioned. When one of us coded a response or finding that others did not, we returned to the data sets, reread them collectively, and discussed whether or not this finding could be confirmed.

Because we have had a great deal of experience analyzing both professionally designed and student-generated visual texts, we paid particular attention to the participants’ references to details, relationships, and discourse patterns. We also took note to what extent participants noticed a relationship between what was said visually (the elements in the ad) to how it was read and interpreted by the dominant culture (social and literacy practices). We found both of these stances helped us do more nuanced and complex readings. In terms of coding participants’ responses, we examined the data sets for participants’ identification of visual elements that they noticed in the ads. For example, one fifth-grader stated, “I also noticed that the colors of the shoes are more pinks and yellows (colors that girls would like).” By coding art elements such as color, we were able to identify which visual and artistic elements the two age groups read and to what extent they had the vocabulary to talk about design and art elements. We also coded responses as critical or not critical. For example, “They are telling you to buy paint at Home Depot. I think they are telling you to buy it because little kids [get] excited,” coded critical. We also coded whether or not participants understood what the advertiser wanted them to buy. For example, in the Disney/Home Depot ad, only six of 21 PTs saw this ad as persuasive; all fifth-graders saw this ad as persuasive. This coding allowed us to notice to what extent these two age groups read the actual visual and written text, as well as the subtext, or the invisible messages that undergird advertisements. We also examined the data sets for ideologies and other discourses that were identified and named. For example, across ads, PTs found that happy smiling children meant a happy home. Further, their descriptors also helped us understand discourses, or the extent to which the viewer identified with the person, objects, and/or setting depicted in the ad. For example, 14 of 21 PTs described children across ads as “cute,” “adorable,” and “happy,” while fifth-graders described children as a “girl” or “boy” or a “little girl;” no value-based adjectives were used. We also counted the frequency with which particular aspects of an ad were mentioned. For example, in the Ralph Lauren ad, fifth-graders believed that the “audience for ad is parents” (5 mentions) and that “nature,” “outdoors,” or “the beach” was the setting (5 mentions). By doing counts of what was noticed, we could more clearly understand which aspects of an ad appealed to which groups of participants and how they were being read. Although we recognize the reading of any text invites multiple interpretations, we have confidence in our assertions. Our independent and collective reading and analysis of participants’ viewings and

responses, as well as our knowledge, experience with, and application of visual methods of analysis (Bang, 2000; Kress & van Leeuwen, 1996; Sonesson, 2005) to a range of visual texts produced in and outside of schools, provide us with confident voices with which to explain viewers' responses to advertisements.

FINDINGS

Several key findings emerged from these data. For purposes of presentation we have organized these around the following themes explained below.

Art Elements and the Reading of Advertisements

Across both age groups participants responded to the art elements of color, size, and shape. When color was of particular importance to an ad, such as the paint swatches from Home Depot, participants identified these colors as significant and seemed to pay particular attention to how they were framed: "...on the paint samples, they write names like 'Ball Gown Blue' and 'Fairy Tale Pink' where normally the names would be 'Blue' and 'Pink'" (a fifth-grader). Despite anomalies of this sort, both sets of participants tended to respond to ads primarily from an aesthetic position. Ads were read for their artistic qualities and their effect rather than how these elements privileged particular cultural groups. Further, they read individual elements independently rather than holistically, or in relationship to each other. The pink and blue were not read in relation to the happy close-up shot of the girl-princess or the bright blue and red paint with the uncluttered and organized room for boys.

Identification with the Context of Ads

Preservice teachers, on the whole, were able to see various discourses within the ads more clearly than fifth-graders, and tended to identify with these discourses more so than fifth-graders. Preservice teachers vicariously saw themselves as parents in the advertised scenes, and used adjectives of value (cute, happy, content) to indicate their positive identification with the people and/or setting of the ad. In the Home Depot/Disney ad, PTs understood that this ad was selling paint; however, they also bought into the discourses of what it means to have a happy, contented childhood and how the color of a child's bedroom might support that outcome. They superficially seemed to associate bright colors with happy and contented children. In answer to the question, How are they trying to convince you to do that [buy a particular product they had identified earlier as being sold]?, PTs responded: "By showing children happy in a bright colored room, as well as fun designs for the paint chips and having the Disney logo;" "By using kids in the ad (that seem to be happy) with colorful rooms [and] then having paint samples next to it." Fifth-graders, when reading this ad, did not identify with the children, nor did they describe them with adjectives of value, and none indicated a desire to have these colors in their own room. Rather, they all saw this ad as persuading the viewer, as parents, to buy these "paint samples...for kids because it has pictures for kids," or the viewer, as kids, because "all kids love Mickey Mouse," and "They make you so excited that you want to shout at your mom and dad to go buy it."

Another of the ads, Ralph Lauren for Children, was particularly interesting in terms of how PTs and fifth-graders identified with it. As in the Home Depot/Disney ad, nearly all of the PTs

described the young child in the ad as “cute,” “little,” “proper,” “pretty young girl,” and “classy.” Such descriptors suggest their vicarious but positive identification with the young child and the lifestyle she represents. They either saw themselves as children, or as parents and how they hoped their own child might look: “...this is a wholesome image of what most parents would probably like their children to dress like;” “It makes parents want to make their daughters look like that.” Fifth-graders were less able to read the ad as ideologically advocating a “proper” or “classy lifestyle.” They noted details in how this ad was doing its work: “By putting a girl in front of the beach;” “There is a little girl that is in a dress and [the ad wants you] to buy summer clothes;” “they want you to buy clothes for us kids.” Unlike the PTs, fifth-graders never used adjectives of value when describing a lifestyle, but used adjectives of concrete description, such as “a girl,” “a little girl,” “us kids.” They did use words such as “cute” to describe the clothing or animals, but not to describe a person or child.

We also found that some slogans, or explicit messages, were read quite easily; however, the implicit messages or the subtext of several ads were completely missed by both sets of participants. When fifth-graders read and interpreted the Big Mac ad where the message, “My buns demand both hands” explicitly implies sex, none picked up on this innuendo. This ad merely reminded them of how hungry they were (“Yummmmm! I want some! I really want it NOW!!”), the size of the burger (“[It] is trying to convince us that it is really big;” “It is so big and juicy and the most biggest sandwich ever.”); and its taste (“delicious,” “luscious,” “You’re in heaven when you eat”). When reading the Wal-Mart Barbie Clothing Line ad, PTs said nothing critical about Barbie, the color scheme of the clothing line, or the anchored images of Wal-Mart and Barbie in the bottom right and left sides of the ad. Their responses were descriptive: “Beautiful little girls, pretty like Barbie. Stylish, pink, walking down the runway like models;” “Showing girls and the dolls in a high-style fashion show. It is portraying the kids as fashion runway models, just like if you wore these clothes, you could be a model, too.”

Use of such general descriptors of value indicates the extent to which viewers of these ads participate and identify with the lifestyle presented in the context of these ads. With the Home Depot/Disney, Wal-mart/Barbie, Ralph Lauren for Children, and Skechers, the designers intend to sell a lifestyle—beautifully decorated rooms, beautifully dressed children confidently marching on a runway, proper and casual dress on a serene and private beach, or comfortable affluence—that children see and adults buy into. The discourses of affluence, professional careers, happy, simple (uncluttered), and content lives are those with which the PTs identified, noticed, and engaged. Fifth-graders identified with the physical elements of the ads, such as the setting, clothes worn, burger size, and puppies.

Appeal of the Advertisements

On the whole, PTs preferred those ads that featured smiling happy children and simple straightforward lifestyles. In particular, they liked the Ralph Lauren for Children ad because “I like their clothes and style and I think this is a cute outfit;” “I liked this ad because of its simplicity and clean image. The ad was not too cluttered or flashy and it was clear what was being sold.” Fifth-graders, on the other hand, saw the Skechers shoe ad as their favorite because “I know the person in it. Puppies are cute,” “...I love the puppies!,” and “it is fun and I like Carrie Underwood.” For PTs, lifestyle is more important. They envision themselves in expensive settings on beaches in preppy clothes. The younger children selected ads, not for the lifestyle per se, but with people that they

knew: Carrie Underwood, Jerry Stackhouse, Britney Spears. They also chose animals; puppies were popular.

Both sets of participants seem to recognize and accept the scenarios presented in the ads. For the PTs, Ralph Lauren is targeted to the wealthy and is an ad of prestige. This knowledge does not seem to faze them. That Carrie Underwood owns a number of very expensive pairs of Skechers is a message of wealth and acquisition that neither set of participants challenged nor questioned.

Critical Reading of Ads

Interestingly enough, each set of participants was less critical than we had anticipated in their reading of these ads. Preservice teachers, however, were even less critical in their reading of ads than were the fifth-graders. On the whole, PTs read these ads more descriptively and concretely than did the fifth graders, "They are showing happy kids with colorful ideas for bedrooms;" "A cute little girl modeling their [Ralph Lauren] clothes;" "Having a pretty young girl model clothing with a nice expression. Outdoors, too;" "Showing a 'fashion' show. Glamour, attention, popular Barbie brand." These descriptions indicate that even though they were asked to identify what was being sold, PTs often did not; instead, they chose to describe the ad by mentioning details they noticed. Fifth-graders answered the question of what was being sold by addressing how an ad was doing its work: "They are convincing girls to buy Barbie girl from Wal-Mart. They are convincing girls to try to be fancy;" "They are trying to convince you to buy this Barbie clothes for us kids so our parents to say 'I want my kids to dress fancy like that' ;" "I think these things are for eight-year-olds because they are old enough to want to look good but young enough to like Barbies." One fifth-grader was particularly good at reading ads with a critical eye: "Carrie Underwood fans might (if they are gullible) say, 'Oh wow, Carrie Underwood wears Skechers shoes. Hmmmmmm, since she is, I will!;" "...there is Britney, belly and abs exposed, in all these poses, that expression on her face, some girls will say, 'I feel like Britney on these roller blades.' Of course, there are girls like me who say, 'Not working.'" Or, in response to the Big Mac ad, she states, "First off, they are asking me, 'Are you MAC enough?' My response, only when I am not moaning about America [being] the most revolting fast food nation, is 'No.'"

Even though we thought the ads that we selected would elicit critical commentary, we found that PTs, on the whole, did not choose to read them this way, while fifth-graders noticed their persuasive intention. Preservice teachers' interpretive approach was one of identification with the scene being presented (Ralph Lauren—their role as parents; Skechers Shoes—comfortable scene, "makes me want to buy a puppy"). In the Skechers ad, two PTs noticed that they were selling Carrie Underwood and "anything at Macy's." One PT saw the Home Depot/Disney ad as advertising "anything Disney." In terms of critical responses, we were the most surprised at the lack of a critical reading of Wal-Mart and their Barbie Clothing Line. Although each set of participants noticed that the ad featured Barbie, and over 60% noticed the Wal-Mart Logo, there was no mention by PTs about the controversy surrounding Barbie as a role model and/or Wal-Mart's unfair working practices. They mentioned the runway, fashionable clothing, accessories, and the color pink. Several fifth-graders, on the other hand, did critically remark on Barbie ("...want you to buy these plastic ugly dolls when they don't do anything for you but look at you with a fat smile;" "...are targeting little girls who want to be all grown up, and they want you to buy stuff at Wal-Mart...").

DISCUSSION

Reading advertisements, without critical awareness of the explicit and implicit messages, suggests that more work in classrooms needs to be done. Given the responses of these participants, their lack of critical analysis of the implicit messages, we suggest that designers for companies operate with knowledge that the consumer does not pay attention to what is being said, nor necessarily how it is said. In other words, consumers, both young and old, are buying the lifestyle being presented in the colorful and active scenes. Designers create, over time, metaphors of truth about their products: those who wear Ralph Lauren live a simple and sophisticated life; if you (or your children) wear the Barbie line of clothing, you (or your children) are “in,” meaning “in good company,” running with the right crowd. Metaphors of truth are established through designers’ and photographers’ effective use of art elements in their ads. When Carrie Underwood gazes directly at the viewer in a soft way, as Kress and van Leeuwen (1996) might argue, she is on display, behind glass, for the viewer to look at and interact with vicariously. Over time, designers/photographers teach viewers to see and read this gaze, engage in the scene, and desire this lifestyle. Even though these ads are texts of persuasion, very few participants actually interrogated the way in which these messages of consumerism were being presented. Lifestyle metaphors are read as truth and internalized unquestioningly to the point that they are not even mentioned by everyday consumers like PTs and fifth-graders.

Beach (2007) argued that the internalization of such truths masks the more insidious work these ads do. That fifth-graders, after reading the Big Mac ad, wanted a burger “right NOW!!” suggests that their desire to eat this burger outweighs the lesser known and publicized facts of fat content in menu items in fast food restaurants. Companies create campaigns that spike our attention and inspire our “need” for these products and mask issues surrounding the making and developing of these products. Consider the depletion of the rain forests to make way for more cattle, which contributes to global warming, or the exploitation of children laborers to make clothing products. Yet, this information is rarely covered in (television) media, especially during times of the day targeted at youth. Rather, what is advertised is an on-the-go lifestyle with children and adults, both busy in activities, who go out for or call in dinner. Thus, we more clearly understand how an ad like McDonald’s elicits hunger rather than critical reflection. Companies rely on our desire to own and to consume. They hope we do not question how these products get into our stores. This is what Edelsky (1999) meant when she said we have to understand that we are operating within systems of meaning while we are trying simultaneously to understand the systems of meaning operating on us.

In concert with desire is recognition, especially of logos, brand names, and people, all marketed to encourage consumerism. While nearly all of the participants noticed the labels, brands and logos, few attempted to read them critically. A more critical reading is that Ralph Lauren is dictating America’s taste. The Ralph Lauren ad seems to invite the viewer to dress his or her child “from head to toe” in Ralph Lauren clothing. This appears to be just the message that PTs in this study wanted to see and hear. Many of the PTs come from middle-class homes and, therefore, engage with the discourses of affluence, professional careers, happy, simple (uncluttered), and content lives that money can buy. The ad’s implicit message is that sophisticated clothes and an uncomplicated lifestyle are to be privileged from childhood through adulthood, and Ralph Lauren can help! With more buying power, PTs see that they can and will, some day, have these products in their own home

or on their own children. They vicariously engage with the uncomplicated and clean-lines lifestyle as parent-consumers. Fila, Skechers, McDonald's, Home Depot/Disney sell their lifestyles in much the same way. Over time, viewers learn to read the schematic codes of the visual text (Albers, 2008), recognize them, and create in their own minds a frame which reflects these lifestyles. Even ads that represent lives of violence are masked in positive ways. For example, even though there is political dissonance about the US involvement in Iraq, none of the participants found the army ad problematic, nor did they mention any possibility of a lost son or daughter through combat. Viewers of this ad, even fifth-graders, saw this ad as "inspirational," "simple," and "all-American."

These readings may be due to PTs' inability, or resistance to, seeing themselves or their future children in spaces of violence (war) by nature of their career choice—teachers—and in safe spaces (home) that are sleek, modern, and affluent, a lifestyle represented by well-dressed children on the beach or on a catwalk. They recognize the importance of soldiers defending their country and only participate in celebrating the bravery of other fathers' children. Designers of US army ads have succeeded, over time, in teaching viewers to see enlistment in the army as promising to help you or your son grow up and as an experience which will allow them to "see the world." The entire group of PTs in our pilot study thought this ad was so wholesome that it could be framed and hung in one's living room.

Based upon responses given by these participants, we argue that critical conversations in classrooms matter. In the fifth-grade class we studied, it was evident that this teacher or the teachers before her engaged these students, at least in part, in critically reading the world. A large number of these children saw these texts as "convincing" them of something; they were aware at some level of the marketers' intentions: "The developers want you to buy these plastic ugly dolls..."; "They are targeting little girls who want to be all grown up..."; "They are trying to convince us to buy the Mickey Mouse, different color paint, and then the kids tell their parents to buy it for them. That is how Home Depot gets the money." These fifth-graders do not seem to identify with these products or the lifestyles that they represent. This may be in large part because their teacher engages them in critical discussion about texts. Additionally, they would not typically spend their own money on such products. With smaller buying power, children spend money for more immediate and social products, such as food, but not clothes, which they expect adults in their home to buy. Preservice teachers were less critical than their fifth-grade counterparts. This finding suggests to us that these PTs have had few experiences reading popular texts, like advertisements, critically, and/or have subsumed the metaphors of truth about human existence that designers visually create. If PTs come to the reading of persuasive texts, such as advertisements, with a naïveté and an aesthetic stance towards products that look beautiful, this discourse of consumerism will not be ruptured. This finding adds credence to our suspicion that their instructional history has not invited critical readings or encouraged them to take on a critical stance. In essence, educators must recognize the significance of everyday texts and how they implicate viewers as consumers, and engage their students across ages in critical analyses of explicit and implicit messaging within these texts. It is particularly problematic in our view that PTs focused on individual elements within an ad, but failed to see how these elements worked together, with the result that implicit, and often very ideological, messages were left unpacked.

Situating the Popular into a Critical Discomfort

As critical educators, we continually challenge teachers and ourselves to bring in and study texts that position us uncomfortably. Megan Boler (1999; Boler & Zembylas, 2003) argued that educators and students alike must critically challenge their own values and beliefs, a stance she called a “pedagogy of discomfort” (1999, p. 175). Rather than emphasize the importance of individual self-reflection, historically recognized as characteristic of American individualism, Boler (1999) suggested that we must participate in “collective witnessing,” (p. 176) or an engagement which invites everyone to see things differently. This requires educators and students to move outside of their comfort zone, to move beyond consensus as an accepted social practice. For example, rather than suggest that advertisements be discussed as persuasive consumer-driven texts, educators might extend an invitation to explore these texts in light of how they position women in particularly superficial ways, often with attention on domestic activity or sexual appeal. Such a shift in discussion and collective witnessing is an enactment of Boler’s concept of discomfort. This discussion positions the collective community, the classroom, to explore issues that are uncomfortable and which may lead to more transformative thinking and action.

Considering the critical in light of discomfort also invites community members of all racial and cultural groupings to examine values that position some as more powerful than others. As students and teachers become more critically aware of the techniques used by designers, companies and marketers, they become consciously more aware of the schematic visual coding that is needed for a more critical or close reading of such texts. With support, close readings of this sort can lead to a much needed interrogation of one’s values and beliefs. Further, critical readings require a more conscious effort on the part of educators to become knowledgeable about art as a language system, visual elements that we notice, the physical arrangement of visual information on the canvas, and how these elements operate together to elicit a particular response.

Further Research

In collecting advertisements for this study we noted that teen magazines contained a whole different set of advertisements for the same product (for example, Skechers) than did parent magazines. In the teen magazine, Skechers footwear was featured within a vampire-like setting, whereas in *Parents Magazine*, Sketchers was advertised using Carrie Underwood and golden retriever puppies. McDonald’s advertised its corporate salad in *People Magazine*, but “My buns demand both hands” on its teen Web site. All this is to say that much more research is needed. Exposing how companies exploit children is only one topic of many that merits further investigation. All final readings of texts—be they linguistic or visual—are ethical readings. This message needs to be highlighted in both PT courses as well as public school classrooms if we are to create a critically literate population for the 21st century.

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